

Thanksgiving: An American Tradition

The American holiday of Thanksgiving is celebrated every year on the fourth Thursday in November. The holiday is during autumn -- the main season for harvesting crops. Thanksgiving is an autumn harvest festival like those found in many cultures around the world.

On this day, most Americans gather with friends and family. Many take time to think about what they are thankful for, cook up a storm, and eat.

A lot.

The star of most Thanksgiving dinners is a roasted turkey. Turkeys are large birds native to North America.

This Oct. 12, 2015, photo shows a roasted Thanksgiving turkey in Concord, New Hampshire, United States. (AP Photo/Matthew Mead)

The turkey is cooked in an oven for many hours, often with a mix of celery, bread, onions and spices inside the bird. This mix becomes stuffing -- another star of the Thanksgiving dinner table.

Anna Matteo here at Learning English says the smell of turkey and stuffing roasting together is the quintessential smell of Thanksgiving. "Quintessential" means the perfect example of something.

After the bird is cooked, the stuffing is taken out and served as a side dish.

One of many side dishes. Families often make other foods like mashed potatoes, sweet potatoes, cranberry sauce and vegetable casseroles. A casserole is a dish that cooks slowly in an oven.

And do not forget about the gravy. This rich sauce is made from the fatty liquid that comes off the turkey as it cooks. People cover their turkey meat, stuffing and mashed potatoes with gravy.

The meal does not end with the turkey, stuffing, and side dishes, though. For some people, the best part of the meal is dessert.

This October 12, 2015 photo shows citrus pumpkin meringue pie in Concord, NH. (AP Photo/Matthew Mead)

The quintessential Thanksgiving dessert is pie. Pumpkin, cherry, apple or pecan pie are all great ways to finish off a Thanksgiving meal...if you are not too full of food by that point!

Thanksgiving travel

Some Americans must travel long distances to be with their families. In fact, the Sunday after Thanksgiving is the busiest travel day of the entire year. This is usually when people return home from family gatherings.

Not everyone can make the return home each Thanksgiving. So, young people living in cities away from their hometowns sometimes celebrate “Friendsgiving” -- a Thanksgiving meal with their friends instead of their family. They gather at someone’s apartment or house and have a “potluck.” This is a meal where everyone who is invited brings food to share with others.

FILE - The Tom Turkey float rides in the Macy's Thanksgiving Day Parade on Thursday, Nov. 23, 2023, in New York. (Photo by Charles Sykes/Invision/AP)

Beyond the table

Thanksgiving is a big day for television, games and other entertainment.

One tradition is the television broadcast of Macy’s Thanksgiving Day Parade. It takes place each year in New York City. Workers of the Macy’s store on Herald Square organized the first parade in 1924. Many of the workers were immigrants and wanted to hold a big parade like the ones in Europe. So, they dressed in costumes and borrowed some animals from the zoo. They also carried small balloons that floated just overhead.

Many professional American football games are also played on Thanksgiving. Fans of the sport enjoy relaxing and watching a game or two after eating a big Thanksgiving meal.

Some start Thanksgiving Day early - and in a healthy way. So-called “Turkey Trot” races take place in many towns and cities. These events involve runners dressing up in a Thanksgiving-related costume and running a short distance -- usually five kilometers.

FILE - A runner with a hat shaped into a piece of pumpkin pie with whipped cream takes part in the 40th annual Turkey Trot to raise money for the Denver chapter of the United Way in south Denver on Thursday, Nov. 28, 2013. (AP Photo/David Zalubowski)

Many Turkey Trots urge runners to bring canned food to donate to local food banks -- non-profit organizations that give food to poor people in a community.

Serving those less fortunate

Certainly, not everyone in America has an easy Thanksgiving. The United States is home to many poor and homeless people. Some cannot afford a Thanksgiving dinner. Others are without friends or families. Many religious and service organizations around the country try to fill these needs. Some provide community dinners at churches and other centers. Some groups also deliver Thanksgiving meals to people too sick or old to leave their homes.

The writer O. Henry called Thanksgiving the one holiday that is purely American. It is not linked to a religion or a certain group. Anyone in the United States on the fourth Thursday of November is welcome to celebrate Thanksgiving.

I'm Caty Weaver.

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Ashley Thompson wrote this story for Learning English. It was first published in 2017.

Vocabulary

festival - n. เทศกาล, งานฉลอง, ช่วงเวลาหรือเหตุการณ์พิเศษที่ผู้คนมารวมตัวกันเพื่อเฉลิมฉลองบางสิ่ง

up a storm - idiom. ทำสิ่งใดสิ่งหนึ่งด้วยพลังงานหรือความกระตือรือร้นอย่างมาก

roasted - adj. ที่ผ่านการอบ, ที่ปรุงโดยใช้ความร้อนแห้งในเตาอบหรือบนกองไฟ

stuffing - n. ไส้, ส่วนผสมของอาหารที่ปรุงรสแล้วซึ่งใส่ไว้ในอาหารอื่นแล้วนำไปปรุง

potluck - n. การรวมตัวกินอาหารที่แต่ละคนนำอาหารมาร่วมแบ่งปันกัน

Reading Comprehension Quiz

1. When is the American holiday of Thanksgiving traditionally celebrated each year?

On the first Thursday in November

On the fourth Thursday in November

On the last Sunday in October

On the second Monday in December

2. Which of the following activities is NOT mentioned as something most Americans do on Thanksgiving Day?

Gathering with friends and family

Taking time to think about what they are thankful for

Decorating a Christmas tree

Cooking and eating a lot of food

3. What is considered the main attraction of most Thanksgiving dinners?

Mashed potatoes

Cranberry sauce

Roasted turkey

Vegetable casseroles

4. What is 'stuffing' typically made from and how is it prepared for Thanksgiving?

It's a sauce made from turkey drippings and served separately.

It's a mixture of celery, bread, onions, and spices cooked inside the turkey.

It's a dessert consisting of various fruits baked together.

It's a side dish of potatoes and vegetables, steamed until tender.

5. According to Anna Matteo, what does 'quintessential' mean in the phrase 'the quintessential smell of Thanksgiving'?

A rare and unusual example of something

A strong and unpleasant example of something

The perfect example of something

A historical and forgotten example of something

6. Which of the following is NOT listed as a common side dish served with Thanksgiving dinner?

Mashed potatoes

Sweet potatoes

Green bean casserole

Tacos

7. How is gravy typically prepared for a Thanksgiving meal?

It is a sweet sauce made from cranberries.

It is a rich sauce made from the fatty liquid that comes off the turkey as it cooks.

It is a light sauce made from blended vegetables.

It is a thick sauce made from mashed potatoes.

8. What is considered the 'quintessential Thanksgiving dessert'?

Ice cream sundae

Chocolate cake

Various types of pie

Fruit salad

9. What is notable about the Sunday immediately following Thanksgiving?

It is a day for major sales at shopping malls.

It is the busiest travel day of the entire year.

It is a day when most Americans start decorating for Christmas.

It is when families traditionally gather for a second Thanksgiving meal.

10. What is 'Friendsgiving' and who often celebrates it?

A holiday specifically for celebrating friendships throughout the year, celebrated by everyone.

A meal where friends gather to exchange gifts, primarily celebrated by children.

A Thanksgiving meal shared among friends instead of family, common for young people living away from home.

A community event organized by local churches for new immigrants to the U.S.

11. What inspired the Macy's Thanksgiving Day Parade when it first started in 1924?

A desire to promote new products in the Macy's store.

Immigrant workers at Macy's who wanted to recreate big European parades.

A celebration of American independence and history.

A charity event to raise money for the poor.

12. Besides family gatherings and parades, what other entertainment is popular on Thanksgiving Day?

Professional American football games

Concerts by famous musicians

International chess tournaments

Broadway theater performances

13. What is a 'Turkey Trot' race?

A cooking competition to prepare the best turkey.

A relay race where participants carry a turkey.

A running event, usually 5 kilometers, where participants may wear Thanksgiving-related costumes.

A dance competition where participants imitate turkeys.

14. What charitable activity is associated with many 'Turkey Trots'?

Collecting toys for underprivileged children.

Raising money for animal shelters.

Urging runners to bring canned food to donate to local food banks.

Organizing blood donation drives.

15. According to the writer O. Henry, what unique characteristic defines Thanksgiving among American holidays?

It is the oldest American holiday.

It is the only holiday celebrated with a parade.

It is purely American and not linked to a specific religion or group.

It is the holiday with the largest family gatherings.